

The revolving door in the revenue seat

By Jason Rigolli — Founder, Revved for Growth · <https://fixyourrevenueengine.com/insights/revolving-door-revenue-seat/>

TL;DR. Mark is writing termination talking points for his third revenue leader in four years, editing the same document he used last time. When three different people fail in the same seat with the same symptoms, that is not three hiring mistakes, it is data about the seat. Firing a leader feels like action, but count the real cost: severance, search fees, and months of lost pipeline while the team stops taking coaching seriously, roughly twelve to eighteen months of lost compounding per cycle. Most revenue seats fail because the leader never had authority, data, or time, not because the candidates were weak. Before the next search, spend thirty days running a Revenue Engine Inspection: find where deals actually die, check what the forecast is really worth, and read what the last few exit interviews all said. Mark ran the inspection instead of the search, and it turned out his last three leaders had already told him what was wrong.

It is Sunday night and Mark is writing termination talking points for his third revenue leader in four years.

He still has the document from the last one, so he is mostly editing. Same missed-forecast bullets. Same line about pipeline that never materialized. Different name at the top. His board has already told him what went wrong: the search was rushed, the recruiter was mediocre, this time they should go upmarket and pay for a real operator.

Reading two nearly identical termination documents side by side, Mark is starting to suspect the problem is not the names.

He is right. When three different people fail in the same seat with the same symptoms, that is not three hiring mistakes. That is data about the seat.

The most expensive way to avoid inspecting your revenue engine is to keep firing the person who runs it.

Three names, one termination document

Firing a revenue leader feels like action. It is visible, it is decisive, and it gives the board something to approve. It is also the slowest possible way to fix revenue.

Count what one cycle actually costs. Severance for a senior leader. Search fees, typically a quarter to a third of first-year compensation. Then the part nobody puts in the deck: four to six months before the new hire is producing, during which pipeline built on the old leader's relationships quietly ages out, the team stops taking coaching seriously because they have learned that leadership is temporary, and every open deal gets re-qualified by someone who was not there for the first conversation.

Call it twelve to eighteen months of lost compounding per cycle. Do it three times and you have spent four years and most of a growth stage discovering that the candidates were fine.

For a company doing seven or eight million with a real product and real customers, that is not a rounding error. That is the difference between the company you have and the company you thought you were building.

And here is what makes the pattern so hard to see from the founder's chair: each individual firing was defensible. The forecast missed. The pipeline was thin. The leader could not explain why. Every one of those is a fair reason to make a change. Three of them in a row is a different conversation.

What the seat looks like from the inside

The obvious objection is a good one, and it deserves a straight answer. A strong revenue leader is supposed to rebuild the engine. That is the job. If three of them could not do it, maybe the hiring bar is the problem, and blaming the system is just a comfortable way to keep hiring people who cannot fix systems.

That objection holds in companies where the seat comes with three things: authority, data, and time. Most of these seats come with none of them.

Authority, because the founder still owns the largest relationships. Not formally, but in practice. The biggest accounts still call him directly, the pricing exceptions still route through him, and the new leader learns quickly that the real revenue function has two heads and only one of them can be fired.

Data, because there is rarely any instrumentation worth the name. Stage definitions mean different things to different people. Nobody can say where deals actually die, only where they were sitting when they stopped moving. The new leader spends the first quarter building a picture of the business that should have existed before the search started, and gets asked in month three why the forecast is not improving yet.

Time, because the quota clock starts on day one. The leader is asked to diagnose a system, rebuild it, and hit the number in the same quarter, using a team hired under the previous design.

A strong operator in that seat does not fail because they are weak. They fail because they were handed a broken engine, half the controls, and a stopwatch.

Role clarity is not an HR exercise. It is system design. In one engagement with an investment banking client, the first thing we built was not a pipeline or a comp plan. It was an accountability chart: who owns what, at which stage, and what happens at every handoff. Deal flow was never the problem. The absence of a named owner at each step was. Once the ownership was explicit, the pipeline became something leadership could inspect rather than something they had to interpret.

That work does not require a new hire. It requires somebody willing to look at how revenue is actually produced before deciding who to blame for it.

What to do before the next hire

Before you open another search, spend thirty days answering four questions with evidence rather than opinion.

Where do deals actually die, by stage and by segment? What is your forecast worth, measured against what closed? Are your managers coaching against live calls, or reporting numbers upward? And what does the last leader's exit interview say that the last two also said?

That last question is the cheapest and the most uncomfortable. If three people described the same constraint on the way out, you have already been told what is wrong.

We call this a Revenue Engine Inspection. The name matters less than the sequence: diagnose the system, fix the two or three things that pay back fastest, then decide what kind of leader the seat actually needs. Sometimes the answer is still a new hire. Often the job description changes completely, because the thing you were hiring for was never the constraint.

Mark ran the inspection instead of the search. It turned out his last three leaders had all flagged the same qualification problem in their first ninety days. Nobody acted on it, because acting on it would have meant changing how the founder sold.

The fourth hire is going to do much better.

If you are on your second or third revenue leader and the termination documents are starting to look alike, [let's talk](#) before you open the next search.



About the author — Jason Rigolli

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Jason Rigolli fixes the reason a company isn't hitting its number. A two-time co-founder with three CRO seats and over two decades rebuilding revenue engines, he works inside founder-led, family-owned, and PE-backed B2B firms (\$2M-\$15M) across winning, keeping, and growing customers.

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